

Let's take this analogy a step further. Imagine if I walked into any office block and prescribed a one-size-fits-all eating plan for everyone—similar to how some financial advisors dictate a 50 per cent needs, 20 per cent savings and 30 per cent wants spending plan. Let's say I also prescribe equal food portion sizes and identical foods and insist everyone eats everything on their plate. No more, no less.

This one-size-fits-all plan wouldn't just be problematic, it would potentially be harmful. I'd be ignoring the fact that some people are vegan, vegetarian or have allergies or intolerances, never mind their different food preferences or levels of physical activity. And let's not forget those who have an unhealthy obsession with food—our compulsive eaters or dieters. How are they going to react to the new food regime?

Or perhaps we might think about how we've been taught to classify people financially, as spenders or savers. With that thinking, I could dictate two different eating plans. One for those who were over a certain weight limit and one for those who were under it. In doing this, I suspect not only would I make people unhappy with the food I was dictating, but now I would be insulting them.

It's easy to see how this homogeneous approach fails when we apply it to food, so why do we insist on prescribing one-size-fits-all regimes to money management?

As with food, the financial approach that works for me is not the one that works for my husband. That's because our Financial Phenotypes are also different. I'm talking opposite ends of the spectrum different. (I'll talk more about this as we move through this book.) In our case, we've recognised that and work hard to make sure both our financial needs are being met. This helps us both feel financially motivated and financially safe, two equally important and often-overlooked concepts. With research consistently telling us that money is the number one thing couples fight about, wouldn't it be nice to move from frustration, judgement and even anger to understanding why we each behave with money the way we do? To understand how both we and our partners can be financially safe and satisfied?

Once you realise the one-size-fits-all financial approach so many of us have been adopting doesn't work for most of us, it can be liberating.